

BALANZONI BURRO E SALVIA

REGION	SERVES	TOTAL TIME
North	4-6	2 h plus the dough rest

INGREDIENTS

120 g	Mortadella, in one piece
604 g	Ricotta
30 g	Parmigiano-reggiano for the filling, finely grated
quantity not given	Nutmeg, whole
3/4 tsp	Salt
1 batch	Green dough
150 g	Unsalted butter, cold and cubed
15	Sage leaves, small
22 g	Parmigiano-reggiano to finish, finely grated
quantity not given	Black pepper

METHOD

1. Chill the meat grinder and its small die in the refrigerator at least 1 hour, or 30 minutes in the freezer.
2. Fit the small die and run the mortadella through twice.
3. Push the ricotta through a tamis or a fine-mesh strainer into a small bowl. Add the mortadella and the 30 g of parmigiano and stir until evenly blended.
4. Grate in 5 or 6 passes of nutmeg, stir, and taste. It should sit in the background at this stage, because it blooms once the pasta is cooking.
5. Add the 3/4 tsp salt and taste again. Mortadellas differ in salt and spice, so more may be needed. Aim for properly seasoned. Cover it and refrigerate until you need it.
6. Make 50 to 60 balanzoni from the green dough and the filling.
7. Salt a large pot of water heavily and bring it to a boil over high heat.
8. While the water heats, set a small saucepan over medium heat and cook half the butter 3 to 4 minutes, to just past golden brown. Drop in 5 of the sage leaves and take the pan off the heat. This gets drizzled over the plated pasta.
9. Set a large saute pan over low heat, add 2 ladles of pasta water (115 g) and the rest of the butter, and swirl to emulsify. Take it off the heat.
10. Drop the balanzoni in and bring the water down to a gentle simmer rather than a rolling boil. Cook 1 to 2 minutes. They are done when the thickest seal has gone tender.
11. Return the saute pan to low heat. Lift the pasta across with a spider or pasta basket and raise the heat to medium. Swirl 30 seconds to 1 minute, turning the pieces with a spoon so every side gets coated. A splash of pasta water loosens the sauce if it tightens.
12. Divide between bowls. Finish with the 22 g of parmigiano, grated nutmeg and black pepper, spoon the sage butter over, and scatter the remaining sage leaves.

NOTES

Simmer, do not boil. That filling is fragile and comes apart if the water is moving hard.
 The 150 g of butter is split in two. Half browns with 5 sage leaves and goes over the plate at the end. Half emulsifies with pasta water into the pan sauce.
 Doneness is judged at the thickest closure point, not at the body of the pasta.
 Ricotta salata and smoked ricotta salata are both given as alternatives to the parmigiano finish.
 Balanzoni are said to have come out of tortellini, the tortellini filling cut with ricotta.

FILLING

Mortadella and Ricotta Filling

INGREDIENTS

120 g	Mortadella, in one piece
604 g	Ricotta
30 g	Parmigiano-reggiano, finely grated
quantity not given	Nutmeg, whole
3/4 tsp	Salt

METHOD

1. Chill the meat grinder and its small die in the refrigerator at least 1 hour, or 30 minutes in the freezer.
2. Fit the small die and run the mortadella through twice.
3. Push the ricotta through a tamis or a fine-mesh strainer set over a small bowl. Add the mortadella and the parmigiano and stir until evenly blended.
4. Grate in 5 or 6 passes of nutmeg, stir, and taste. Adjust to suit, keeping it in the background.
5. Season with the salt and taste again. Mortadellas vary in salt and spice, so more may be needed. Aim for properly seasoned. Cover it and refrigerate until you are ready to pipe.

NOTES

Nutmeg blooms as the pasta cooks, so it should read as restrained in the raw mixture rather than forward. The ratio is what matters. Mortadella is there to lend salt and savor to the ricotta, not to take it over. Passing the ricotta through a tamis is what makes the filling smooth enough to pipe cleanly. The 3/4 tsp of salt is a starting point only, because different mortadellas arrive at very different salt levels. The mixture is loose and delicate. Pasta filled with it wants a gentle simmer, not a rolling boil.

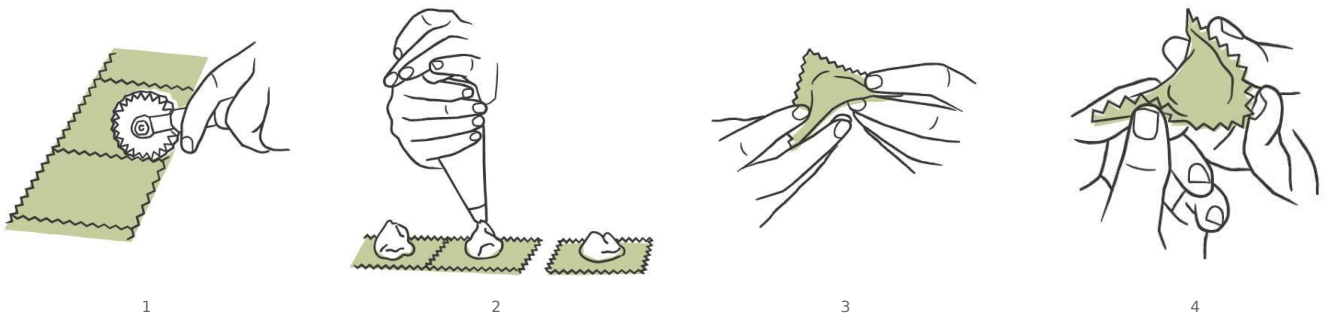
SHAPE

Balanzoni

Region: Emilia-Romagna, city of Bologna / Rest: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered in the refrigerator

METHOD

1. Make the green dough, then roll and sheet it.
2. Dust a wooden board with 00 flour. Cover a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
3. Cut one sheet into 2 1/2-inch squares with a plain-edged or fluted dough divider. A plain or fluted pastry cutter with a ruler, or a knife with a ruler, does the same job. Keep the squares under plastic wrap or a towel.
4. Load the filling into a pastry bag cut to a 1/2-inch opening. Pipe a quarter-sized circle of filling into the middle of each square.
5. If the dough feels dry rather than moderately tacky, mist the squares with a spray bottle held 8 to 10 inches above the board so the seal will hold. Skip this if the dough is already tacky.
6. Hold a square in your palm and bring one corner across to its opposite, edges aligned, making a triangle.
7. Pinch the edge shut around the filling with thumb and index finger. Work back and forth a few times and push all the air out.
8. Press a dimple into the center of the filled side with your index finger.
9. Hold the two bottom points of the triangle and bring them together underneath the filling to form a wide ring, leaving a gap between filling and closure. Pinch that joint tight, then flatten it to roughly the thickness of the rest of the piece so it cooks evenly.
10. Set the piece on the prepared pan. Fill and fold the rest of the squares, keeping them in a single layer, and dust the pan again with semolina.
11. Work through the remainder of the sheet, then the rest of the sheets.
12. Refrigerate uncovered for 45 minutes to 1 hour to dry. Covered pieces sweat and get too wet. To hold longer, lay plastic wrap loosely over the pan and refrigerate up to 8 hours.

SHAPING



5



6



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NOTES

Sheet is cut into 2 1/2-inch squares, one piece per square.

Filling per piece: a quarter-sized circle, piped through a 1/2-inch pastry-bag opening.

Cutter: plain-edged or fluted dough divider.

Seal geometry: fold to a triangle, pinch the edge closed, dimple the filled side, then join the two bottom points beneath the filling into a wide ring. The book specifies a gap between filling and closure, where tortellini are drawn tight against the filling.

Air must be forced out of the edge as you pinch, and the finished joint gets flattened to the thickness of the rest of the piece for even cooking.

Needs the green (spinach) egg dough rather than a plain egg dough.

Storage: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered to dry, then up to 8 hours refrigerated under loose plastic.

Served with a simple butter-based sauce. The classic Bolognese treatment is butter, sage, and parmigiano.

DOUGH

Green Dough

Makes: 998 g / Active Time: 8-10 min kneading, plus blanching / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

454 g, to yield 250 g puree	Spinach leaves
630 g	Tipo 00 flour
118 g	Egg yolks
as needed	Extra 00 flour for kneading

METHOD

1. Blanch the spinach 30 seconds to 1 minute, until tender but still bright green, then straight into ice water.
2. Drain, wrap in a towel and wring out every bit of water. This matters, since leftover water throws the hydration.
3. Blend to a smooth puree, loosening with a tablespoon of water at a time if it will not move.
4. Measure out 250 g of puree. Freeze the excess.
5. Mix the yolks lightly, then stir the puree through them.
6. Mound the flour with a well 5 to 6 inches across, add half the green mixture, drawing in flour with a fork.
7. Add the rest the same way, scraping back any escapes.
8. Knead 8 to 10 minutes until smooth, firm, evenly bright green, with a slight spring back.
9. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes.

NOTES

454 g of leaves cooks down to more than 250 g, so you will have overage. Weigh the puree rather than using all of it.

118 g of yolks is about 6 to 7 eggs, far fewer than plain egg dough, because the puree carries much of the liquid.

For ramp dough, swap half the spinach for leafy ramp tops.

Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____

RATING ____ / 5

OVEN ADJ. _____

NOTES _____